

MAGIC TRICK

I didn't go straight to prison.

The facility was at capacity, so they held me at the local police station instead. Two weeks in limbo — not quite the system yet, but not the world either.

Three of us. All sentenced. All waiting for beds to open up.

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They put us in the day room.

A large space usually reserved for weekend holds — people picked up Friday night, waiting for court Monday morning. Shower stalls in the corner. Toilet. An outdoor area enclosed by brick walls so high you couldn't see anything but the square of sky directly above you.

Two tables bolted to the floor. Concrete everywhere.

The room had a smell. That musk of commercial-grade cleaner that never quite covers what it's supposed to cover. Cold air that seemed to seep from the walls themselves. And an echo — every sound bouncing back at you half a second later, like the room was repeating everything just to make sure you heard it.

During the day, it was dim. Lights went out at sunrise, and there was almost no natural light except what filtered in from the outdoor area. You'd sit in that grey half-dark for hours, watching shadows shift across the concrete as the sun moved overhead somewhere you couldn't see.

The sounds of the station bled through constantly. Keys jingling as officers walked the halls. The clang of locks. The slam of heavy steel doors echoing down corridors.

Even the sound felt cold.

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Mattresses on the floor. Three corners. Three blokes giving each other space.

The other two were Māori. One I don't remember the name of now — shorter guy, long hair, early twenties, in for burglary. The other was Mara.

Six foot. Medium build. Half European. Short hair, well-spoken. In for fraud.

And a heroin addict. High-functioning. On the methadone programme.

You wouldn't have known it to look at him.

After a few days of yarning — filling the hours because there was nothing else to fill them with — turned out he was Stacey's cousin. Second or third, something distant. Small fucking world.

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Weekend holds cycled through. Arrived Friday. Gone by Monday. Left their rubbish around. Spat in the outdoor area.

This was our house now.

Short altercations when required. Nothing major. Just enough.

After a week, the cops figured out we weren't trouble. Left the day room door open. Access to the corridor, a small kitchen for inmate food, a room they used for blood tests.

Coffee and tea whenever we wanted.

Small freedoms. They matter when every hour feels the same.

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Mara got his methadone delivered daily.

Same ritual every time. The sergeant would come to the day room door, call him up. Mara would walk over, take the bottle, drink it in front of him. Open his mouth for inspection. Hand the bottle back.

Supervised consumption. Standard protocol.

One day, we devised a plan.

The blood test room had clean needles. Easy enough to liberate with three of us working together — one distraction, one acquisition, one lookout. We had nothing but time to plan it, and even less to lose.

Then Mara set up two cups in the ablution area, just out of sight from the main room. One filled with water. One empty.

When the sergeant arrived with the prescription, Mara went through the motions. Took the bottle. Raised it to his lips. Then asked for water — casual, polite, nothing unusual.

The sergeant agreed.

Mara walked to the ablution area. Out of sight for maybe three seconds. Emptied the methadone into the waiting cup. Grabbed the one filled with water. Walked back.

Raised the bottle again. Pretended to finish what was never in there.

Took a sip of water to wash it down.

Opened his mouth. Empty. Showed the bottle. Empty. Showed the cup. Empty.

The sergeant nodded, collected the bottle, and left.

Me and the other guy had been watching. Poker faces held — you learn that in places like this. How to show nothing until you're alone.

The sergeant had been standing right there, watching compliance.

He'd actually been watching a magic trick.

Mara looked at us and grinned.

Time for some fun.

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I'd never done heroin before.

Never done any IV drug use at all. Pills, powders, smoke — sure. But needles had never presented themselves, and downers weren't really my thing anyway.

Fuck it. Why not.

Had nothing else to do.

Mara prepared a dose. Small. Safe. First-timer friendly.

I was lean back then. Muscular. Veins like rope under the skin. Mara noticed. Got a little excited about it — good access, clean entry.

He tied me off. Found the vein. Slid the needle in.

No hesitation on my end. I wasn't fearful of anything at that stage of my life. Always willing to give something a go.

The plunger went down.

And the wave hit before it finished.

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Euphoria. Immediate.

Like the drug couldn't wait to reach my bloodstream. Heavy and warm. Cotton wool wrapped around everything.

We moved back to the main room. Sat at the table.

A little nausea. Gone as quick as it came.

I leaned my head against my hand. Mid-sentence.

And then I was gone.

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What felt like a blink was hours.

Late afternoon light filtering in from the outdoor area. Different shades of grey. My lunch sitting next to me on the table — Mara had grabbed it when it came through.

I went to pick up where I'd left off. Mid-sentence. Mid-thought. Like no time had passed.

Mara was watching from across the table.

"Oh, he's back."

Calm. Amused. Like I'd stepped out for a smoke and wandered back in.

He'd grabbed my lunch. Kept an eye on me while the high worked through. Made sure the first-timer didn't stop breathing.

That was Mara.

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Two weeks passed.

Then they moved me. First of the three to go.

I caught Mara one more time inside — couldn't see him, just heard his voice calling out from another yard during unlock. He'd spotted me walking past. A few words shouted across concrete. That was it.

The other guy, I never saw again.

Mara and I caught up on the outside, after release. But that's another story.

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